

Architecture's noisy soul-searching

Some big professional guns zero in on the trendy Post-Modernists

By Robert Campbell

Is American architecture careening along on a "hedonistic binge" after decades of sober Modernism?
And if it is, should we cry or cheer?

Architects are taking sides on that issue noisily and publicly. This year was supposed to be a "Celebration of Architecture," according to the American Institute of Architects (AIA), but instead it's turned out to be the year when all the esthetic wars long raging in the profession finally went public.

The press has loved it. Time, Newsweek, the Museum of Modern Art all bannered the same idea: Something called "Modernism" was dead, and, at its wake, the heirs were partying it up. The old bare-bones skinflint was gone at last, and dawning was a new age of something called Post-Modernism, a trendier architecture, a frothy mix of pop Las Vegas with a delicatessen of other styles picked from the shelves of history.

The event that loosed this gush of prose was the awarding of the AIA's Gold Medal a year ago in Dallas to ex-Modernist Philip Johnson, who used the occasion to discuss his Chippendale-top AT&T building for New York. He brought with him a squad of up-to-date younger architects who then seemed to spend most of the rest of the year carrying the good word about Post-Modernism to campus and seminar all across the land.

Well, it turned out, not everyone agreed. The year ended, early this month in Kansas City, with another AIA convention, a far more conservative Gold Medalist—I. M. Pei—and a clutch of stern, tongue-lashing puritans who took to the

podium to say that this time the younger generation had gone too far.

What gave this convention its special eerie quality was the unexplained collapse of Kansas City's indoor sports stadium, the Kemper Arena, only a few blocks from the convention. Just three years ago the Kemper was one of six buildings to win national honor awards from this same AIA.

On Monday of convention week the AIA's elite "Fellows" among them the Kemper's architect, attending from Chicago—dined in black tie to hear gloomy talk from Pietro Belluschi, former dean of architecture and planning at MIT. As they ate, the kind of storm that sent Dorothy to Oz was dropping three acres of the Kemper's roof trusses and bar joists onto its floor. The architect, still in tuxedo, rushed off in the night to see the wreck, and from then on a kind of off-stage moan from the direction of the Kemper played Greek chorus to the orations of the convention.

When it turned out that many of the convention's speakers were there to thunder about architecture's sins, the Kemper disaster, so disconcertingly timed, came to seem merely just retribution to a profession in thrall to the Gold Calf of Post-Modernism.

Dean Belluschi was the first of these prophets and he left no doubt where he stood.

"Visual delight, impatient with social, technical or moral restraints, is now declared to be the only goal worth pursuing," Belluschi complained. He called the trend "this well-advertised hedonistic binge."

Norris Smith, a professor of the history of art at Washington University in St. Louis, agreed. He said all the trouble began back in the 1870s with the Impressionist painters, to whom "the good life consisted in the enjoyment of the largest

possible number of atomized moments of pleasurable sensations.... Looking at the present-day scene, I would be inclined to say that architects have finally thrown in the sponge and joined the ranks of the hedonistic Impressionists."

As examples, Smith cited the flashy

Hyatt-Regency hotels. "These hotels are made for tourists—for mobile, rootless persons who want to be indulged with as many pleasurable sensations as possible," Smith said. All of us, he implied, are becoming mere tourists of architecture, like the hordes who visit Boston to experience

the Faneuil Hall Markets.

Both Smith and Belluschi lamented the passing of social concern, of the architect who wanted to better the world through architecture. Smith, though, went on to a larger point. Architects, he said, once built mainly for institutions—

for the church, its cathedrals; for the monarchy, its palaces; for the Republic its state houses; for the family its homes. But in our century all public institutions, and the tradition and continuity they represent, have grown weaker.

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Architects fighting, worrying

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Instead of state, church, or family, architects build for "society," or they try "to express the values of the culture" or "the spirit of the age," vague concepts which mean whatever an architect wants them to.

As if on cue, I. M. Pei, the AIA's Gold Medal winner this year, accepted his prize with a speech that exemplified most of what Smith had been ranting against.

Vague impressionism? Said Pei: "Architects, by design, investigate the play of volumes in light, explore the mysteries of movement in space . . . Search for that special quality which is the spirit of the place." Cant about the spirit of the age? Said Pei: "History confirms the fact that architecture is a true mirror of life and time . . . Architects must search for that essential element in our lives which possesses enhancing and ennobling quality."

Pei joined the chorus of gloom too, though. "Today," he said, "the values which inspired those who have stood in this place before me seem to be in doubt and architecture appears to be in two worlds, the world of practice and the world of ideas, each in alienation from the other." Philip Johnson, he told a questioner, is "an idea man."

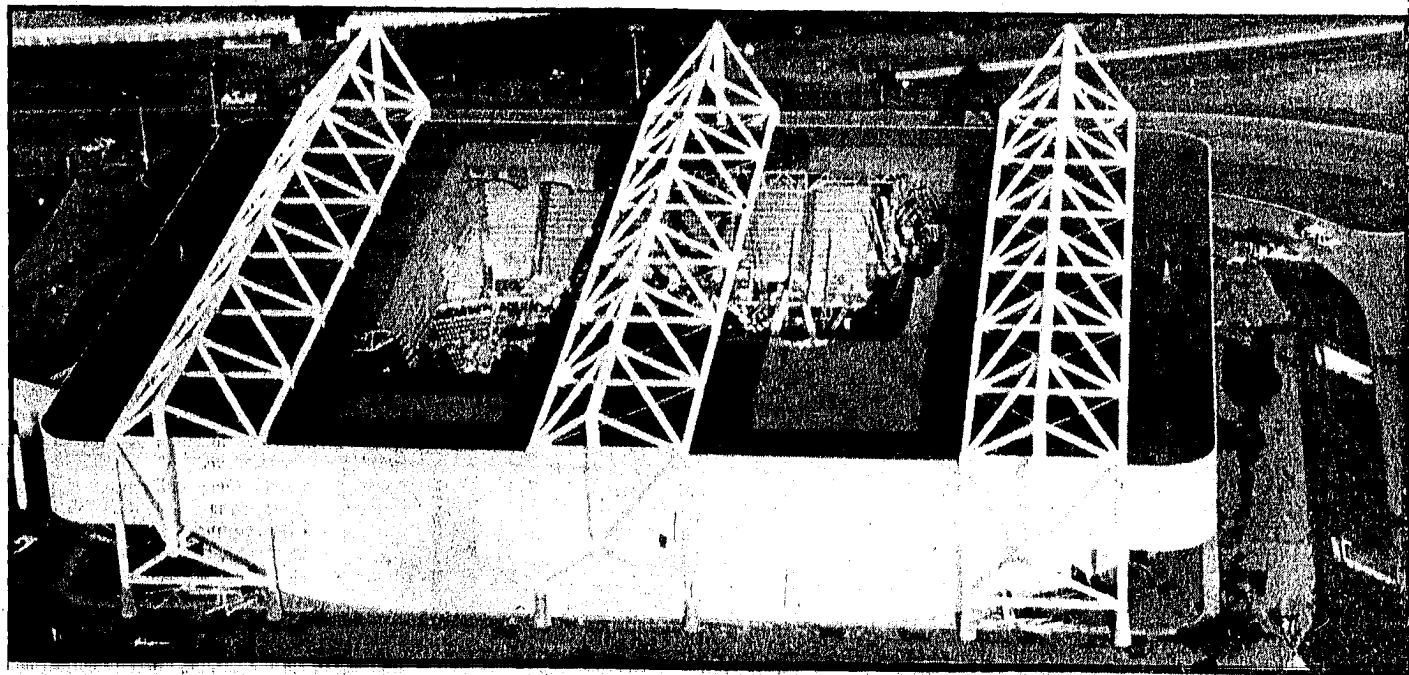
And so it went, all week. The twisted beams of the Kemper seemed the outward manifestation of an inward malaise.

Philip Johnson, the architect most often identified with the kind of frothy hedonism the others were attacking, turned out to be the most outspoken of all. Talking about the older architecture of Kansas City, its fine Art-Deco city hall and earlier, elaborately decorative Beaux-Arts railroad station, he told a dinner audience:

"How did they get the money to build that railroad station? Today we couldn't even draw it, much less build it. Let's be honest, the architecture of our own time has been a bottom."

As if everyone weren't depressed enough, James Q. Wilson, a Harvard government professor, finished up the week with a speech in which he said that neither gas prices nor architects will persuade Americans to live in cities. "Only architects, stewardesses and professors really want to live over the pizza shop in the richly diversified kind of city Jane Jacobs described," Wilson maintained. "Everyone else wants lawns, a safe place to raise children, a small community where public behavior is controlled by shared values."

"People have wanted to get out of cit-



When the roof of Kansas City's Kemper Arena collapsed this month, it was just one of the jolts that could be heard at the AIA Convention.

ies for at least a century. Now, for the first time, a majority can do it."

He pooh-pooed the idea of "gentrification" of the cities and said more people are moving out of cities than into them — and will continue to do so.

Well, Wilson has been saying that for years, and maybe he's wrong. But at the end of a long week in Kansas City his remarks seemed to fit right in.

The question is, what is there left for the poor architect? If he can't believe in

gentrification — or hedonism — or the spirit of the age — or art — or Modernism — or the Kemper Arena — what is left? Liability insurance?

I don't know whether conventions of druggists, or dentists are so relentlessly self-critical. But at the end the feeling,

oddly enough, was one of optimism. People who are worrying this hard about whether they're doing anything right, can't be all bad.

One felt the Kemper would rise again, and, with a little luck, so would architecture.